



ACTION PLAN CoARA OF THE SPANISH NATIONAL RESEARCH COUNCIL (CSIC) 2023-2027

INTRODUCTION

The Spanish National Research Council (CSIC) is a public research organization under the Ministry of Science, Innovation, and Universities. It is part of the Spanish System of Science, Technology, and Innovation (SECTI), conducting both basic and applied research in Life Sciences, Material Sciences, Social Sciences, and Humanities. SECTI is guided by principles of quality, coordination, cooperation, efficiency, competitiveness, transparency, internationalization, results evaluation, equal opportunities, and accountability.

CSIC operates across all Autonomous Communities, contributing to the nation's development through science and knowledge and high-skilled employment. The staff includes 15,000 individuals across 124 centers and institutes.

To fulfill its mission, CSIC undertakes various activities grouped into ten main areas:

- Generation of knowledge through scientific and technical research
- Knowledge and technology transfer
- Expert advisory services
- Pre- and post-doctoral training
- Scientific dissemination
- Territorial and functional structuring of SECTI
- International scientific representation
- Management of major facilities
- Oriented research development



- Independent scientific-technical assistance to Public Administrations

In 2022, CSIC's budget was 1,121 million euros, 47% of which came from competitive funding from local, regional, national, European Union, and international sources.

CONTEXT

The CSIC Strategic Plan, Multiannual Action Plan 2022-2025, approved by the CSIC Governing Council on January 31, 2022, aims to position the institution as one of the most attractive organizations for science development in Europe, attracting and retaining top researchers. The Management Contract for the period 2023-2026 (Order PCM/829/2023, July 20) allows CSIC to plan its objectives adequately and manage its human, financial, and material resources efficiently, ensuring accountability. This contract also enables CSIC to contribute to the European Union and Spain's goal of open strategic autonomy by ensuring our country can produce excellent science and knowledge and establish alliances with other countries.

CSIC joined CoARA in its founding stage in late 2022 and DORA in 2020. The ten CoARA commitments permeate three levels of action: researchers, research, and institutes/groups/departments. CSIC's decision-making capacity in these areas varies significantly.

Regarding **researchers**, the CSIC, like other public research organizationsⁱ, must refer to the Public Employment Offer and what is established in section 2 of article 22 bis of Law 17/2022, which amends Law 14/2011 on Science, Technology, and Innovation. In detail: *"In the Public Employment Offer, within the limit of the replacement rate corresponding to the positions for the recruitment of research staff in the Public Research Organizations, a minimum reserve of 25% of positions will be established for the incorporation of doctoral research staff who have participated in postdoctoral aid programs or subprograms and have obtained the R3 certificate in accordance with article*



22.3 or have passed an equivalent evaluation to the Program for Encouraging the Incorporation and Intensification of Research Activity (I3)."

This externalization processⁱⁱ, currently at a minimum 25% replacement rate for Tenured Scientist positions, favors the State Research Agency (AEI) in evaluating research merits leading to individual researcher assessments. This Action Plan does not include individual researcher evaluations but focuses on CSIC's activities in selecting researchers for awards and recognitions and influencing job profiles based on each institute's needs. In this regard, this Action Plan does not include the individual evaluation of researchers without diminishing the importance of all those actions in which the CSIC selects researchers for proposals or the awarding of, for example, prizes and recognitions, and the opportunities to intervene and influence the topics and profiles of the positions announced according to the needs of each institute in the corresponding selection processes for the recruitment or internal promotion of its researchers. However, the panels retain the task of evaluating the CVs of applicants who are not R3 (or I3). Therefore, it is crucial that CSIC staff, who constitute 50% of each panel, understand this reform process and apply it whenever the officially published selection criteria allow. Additionally, national evaluation programs like the *sexenios* are conducted by state agencies (AEI and ANECAⁱⁱⁱ).

Research in Spain is organized through the State Plan for Scientific and Technical Research and Innovation (PEICTI, X State Plan 2024-2027), which is evaluated by the AEI. The CSIC develops its own research initiatives or programs to promote scientific and technological excellence, foster collaboration among its research groups, or encourage international cooperation. These initiatives always involve an evaluation of the applications, which is mostly carried out internally and is currently being analyzed within the scope of this Plan. For this reason, this Action Plan contemplates establishing a catalogue of programs and the corresponding evaluation systems to ensure their coherence and consistency with the commitments made. Specifically, the pilot project included in this Action Plan falls within this scope of action.



Institutional evaluation at CSIC includes two well-differentiated components in their scope of action, but with the common element of accountability. The first component, productivity by meeting objectives (PCO), has a long-standing tradition at CSIC and involves an annual compilation of the scientific and technical activities carried out in the 124 centers and institutes. The final result of this exercise is a numerical percentage of compliance, so this productivity, by its nature and temporality, can hardly be framed within an evaluation of the research quality of each institute or center. The second institutional component is the Management Contract that CSIC signed in 2023 (Order PCM/829/2023, July 20), which forms an essential basis for the relationship between the Government of Spain and CSIC for the period 2023-2026. Again, it involves achieving strategic objectives through a series of scientific, economic, structural, and other quality indicators, and the degree of compliance and annual control involves a budgetary commitment as well as human resources, making problematic its inclusion in the CoARA context.

CSIC COMMITMENTS TO RESEARCH EVALUATION SYSTEM REFORM

CSIC signed the Agreement during CoARA's founding stage in November 2022. In November 2021, CSIC endorsed the European Commission's report (DG RTD) outlining principles for reforming the evaluation system and signed DORA in 2020.

In June 2023, the CSIC-CoARA Commission was formed, including 15 members from diverse specializations like open science, ethics, scientific areas, scientometrics, and research evaluation. Commission members include both researchers and technical specialists. The Commission meets periodically, organized into three working groups:

1. Analysis of evaluation criteria and methodologies at CSIC
2. Awareness and communication of CoARA commitments
3. CSIC strategy towards CoARA



The Action Plan (2023-2027) includes five phases characteristic of transformation processes:

1. Planning and preparation
2. Implementation
3. Consolidation and expansion
4. Optimization and sustainability
5. Evaluation and final report

Deliberately, the year 2022 is included in the schedule of activities and tasks, indicating that there are programs and initiatives already addressed at CSIC previously, which need to be extended and matured within the framework of this Action Plan.

This Action Plan is a living document, and during the development of phase 1, the gap between the ambition of the milestones and objectives set and the reality of implementation has been observed. For this reason, not all milestones to be achieved are specifically detailed; instead, the activities to be developed are described. This document will be reviewed and updated semiannually with the milestones achieved.

RESOURCES NEEDED FOR ACTION PLAN IMPLEMENTATION

The complexity of the first phase anticipates inherent risks in transforming an institution like CSIC. Specific resources are essential for this purpose:

Phase 1: Conducted with in-kind contributions from the 15 commission members, particularly the coordinator and the three working group coordinators, focusing on internal analysis and institutional reality evaluation.

Phases 2, 3, and 4: The CoARA CSIC Office should be opened in 2025 to coordinate the Action Plan. Initial funding from a CoARA Boost^{iv} project would cover 67% of the salary for the responsible person. Additional resources for these phases include:



- Contract for the Office responsible, Group M3, annual cost: €43,303.19
- Internal Committee, including participants in the ERESIE project, with an estimated budget of €20,000 for awareness campaigns, travel, and expenses.

Total estimated cost for 2025-2027: €150,000.

This plan is aligned with enhancing research evaluation systems for institutional excellence and ensuring sustainable progress in the long term.

ⁱ Instituto de Salud Carlos III (ISCIII), Centro de Investigaciones Energéticas, Medioambientales y Tecnológicas (CIEMAT), Instituto de Astrofísica de Canarias (IAC), Instituto Nacional de Técnica Aeroespacial (INTA, dependiente del Ministerio de Defensa)

ⁱⁱ In the scientific literature, the national research evaluation system has merited the following comment: *"The most unusual case of Research Evaluation System can be found in Spain"* J. Gläser "The social orders of research evaluation systems" p 256. In *"The Changing Governance of the Sciences"* Richard Witley & Jochem Gläser (Eds) 2007.

ⁱⁱⁱ ANECA: Agencia Nacional de la Evaluación y la Acreditación

^{iv} ERESIE: Enhancing Research Evaluation Systems for Institutional Excellence. The financing of the Project in case of concession would be € 60,000 to be executed in 1 year.